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• Editorial Office Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001; Phones: 23315801-4;

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Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton

House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23322233; Fax: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai,

2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Into In; Fax: 28472178; Cable:

Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones:

22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road,

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• 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006;

Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293

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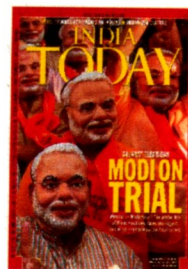
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Like him or not, Chief Minister of Gujarat Narendra Modi is a political phenomenon. In many ways he represents the best and the worst of Indian politics. He is an electoral opportunist who will use any means to get elected—riots, communalism and playing on people's worst fears. Yet he delivers good governance, focussing on economic development, a corruption-free administration and speedy implementation. He is hated in many drawing rooms outside his Gujarat but loved in most of them inside his state. On the national scene, he is most often seen as a malevolent character who abetted the massacre of an estimated 3,000 Muslims in the riots of 2002. Inside the state, as his recent victory in the assembly election shows, he is considered a hero.

This was a critical election for Modi. It was his opportunity to dryclean himself of the image of a sectarian state leader and project himself as a viable national figure for BJP. This was apparent from his initial campaign platform of development. He deliberately stayed clear of his usual communal rhetoric until Congress leader Sonia Gandhi accused his Government of being "merchants of death". This gave him the opening to revert to communal form and cleverly turn the polls into a referendum on himself.

He tackled dissidents within his state party and the hapless national leaders of his hopeless party were of no use to him. Above all was the anti-incumbency factor which has slain most Indian politicians. Despite all this, Modi delivered 117 out of 182 seats to BJP. A remarkable achievement for which all credit goes to him alone.



Our Dec 17 issue

My simplistic expectation of Modi's victory is based on the fact that the Congress could not project any credible regional leader to match him. Sonia Gandhi's helicopter style leadership had very little impact in Gujarat. I believe there is no longer a pan-Indian leader who can sway a local election. This is the price Congress has had to pay for its sycophantic culture where no regional leadership is allowed to flourish.

The Gujarat election result has special import beyond the state: on the precariously-perched UPA coalition, on the general election 16-odd months away and on the doddering BJP.

Our cover story this week analyses the repercussions of the Gujarat poll and demystifies the cult of Modi. Associate editor Uday Mahurkar, who has been based in Ahmedabad with the magazine for 20 years, has always been right in his election predictions about Modi, regardless of what the polls have said. He delves into the Modi model and what makes it work in Gujarat. Our political bureau predicts the national impact of Gujarat result on BJP and the Congress. Editor Prabhu Chawla writes about the return of the authoritative leader and how Modi's victory could redefine the tenor of leadership in Indian politics.

The one thing the Modi victory has done is to get all parties to put on their thinking caps in order to formulate winning strategies in this new power paradigm. We have interesting times ahead.

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)